QUICK GUIDE

SQUARE WAVE

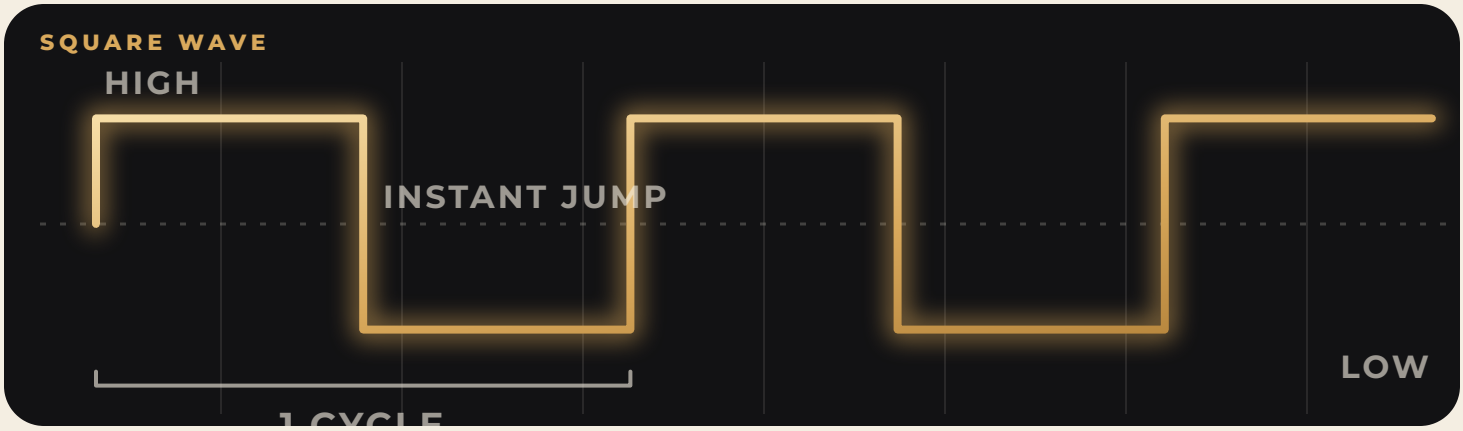
What it is, how to spot it and what to do with it.

WHAT IT IS

A square wave jumps straight between a high level and a low level, with no slope in between. It spends equal time up and down.

HOW IT SOUNDS

Buzzy, hollow and bold. The classic retro game sound.



01

TWO LEVELS ONLY

Up, down, up, down. No curve in between.

02

FLAT TOPS AND BOTTOMS

Instant jumps from one level to the other.

03

ODD HARMONICS

A hollow, buzzy tone. Think retro game sounds.

DO THIS TONIGHT

Spot boxy, flat-topped waveforms. They're loud and harsh.

- [ ] Look at a track's waveform for flat, boxy peaks.
- [ ] Compare a clean track to a harsh one by ear.
- [ ] If your own recordings look boxy, turn down the source.



PRACTICE & CHECK

SQUARE WAVE: YOUR TURN

WHERE YOU'LL MEET IT AS A DJ

- Gritty synth leads and arps use square-style waves.
- Heavily clipped audio starts to look like a square wave.
- Its sharp edges add lots of odd harmonics, so it cuts through a mix.

QUICK CHECK

1. What shape are the tops and bottoms?

2. Which harmonics does a square wave contain?

3. What does clipped audio start to look like?

Answer key: 1) Flat. 2) Odd harmonics only. 3) A square wave.

REMEMBER

Two levels. Hard edges. Buzzy and bold.

YOUR NOTES

UP NEXT Triangle Wave

